

Reconciliation and issues of forgiveness:

Forgiveness

Definition

Forgiveness is the principled decision to **give up your justified right for revenge**; it also requires the forgiver to recognize that the offender is “human like myself.”

Categories

Forgiveness is often categorized as having two distinct forms:

- **Unilateral forgiveness**: This requires nothing in return. It is an act of generosity on the part of the victim(s). There can be many different motives; for instance, it may stem from compassion for an offender, **the wish to free oneself from pain**, or simply a pragmatic means of moving forward.
- **Bilateral forgiveness**: This involves an exchange. It is a **contractual relationship between people or groups, dependent on apology and remorse**. It is often tied up with justice, as it involves the paying of a social debt.

Some Key Points about Forgiveness

- **Process**: Forgiveness is not a single magnanimous gesture in response to an isolated offense, **but a longer-term, fluid, and ever-changing process where people work towards repairing broken relationships, or broken hearts**.
- **Recognition**: Forgiveness is about recognizing that life is messy and unpredictable – that we are all fallible human beings capable of messing up. It requires a broad perspective.
- **Empathy**: Forgiveness is more than just accepting or letting go, because it requires a degree of empathy or compassion. It is the ability to place yourself in someone else's life (empathy) and to act according to this empathic connection you feel towards your fellow human beings (compassion).
- **Reconciliation**: Forgiveness is different from reconciliation, which requires some kind of peace process and the coming together in unity of two or more formerly hostile sides.

Reconciliation

Definition

Reconciliation refers to **the restoration of fractured relationships by overcoming grief, pain, and anger**. It is, as Karen Broenus has written, “a societal process that involves mutual acknowledgment of past suffering and the changing of destructive attitudes and behavior into constructive relationships toward sustainable peace.”

The path toward reconciliation can also be described as a lifelong journey going in two directions: inward, towards self-discovery and reconciling with suffering, and outward, toward recognizing and perhaps forgiving others. It is both an intrapersonal and an interpersonal exercise, each aspect advancing the more deeply a person discovers that reconciliation is possible both within and without.

Some Key Points about Reconciliation

Reconciliation can be seen as a five-step process, including:

1. Developing a shared vision of an interdependent and fair society

2. Acknowledging and dealing with the past
3. Building positive relationships
4. Facilitating significant cultural and attitudinal change
5. Enabling substantial social, economic, and political change.

Naturally, people don't like to (and, frankly, don't want to) forgive. We want to hold on to bitterness because we think, *if I forgive the people who have hurt me, then I'm condoning their actions*. I'm saying what they did is okay. I have to be close with them again. That is not true at all. God is the judge, and He will judge appropriately. Bitterness, lack of forgiveness, and grudges often harm the one holding on to them the most. However, **when we forgive we essentially say, "You can't destroy me, end me or hinder me any longer, because my God heals. He is better than bitterness."** It also shows the world that we truly understand how much God has forgiven us.

Forgiveness and reconciliation can occur in every sphere of human experience, including individual, community, national, and trans-national levels. In any discussion about forgiveness and reconciliation, it is important to make a distinction between the two before analyzing each of them in greater detail. On the one hand, forgiveness does not necessarily mean reconciling with the wrongdoer. There may be good reasons why you do not wish to reconcile. Reconciliation is an additional choice. On the other hand, it is nearly impossible to reconcile with someone you have not gone some way to forgive. Sometimes we hesitate to forgive because we think it must automatically include reconciliation, but in reality these are two separate processes, and one does not always lead to the other.

ONE PERSON CAN FORGIVE; IT TAKES TWO TO RECONCILE

The reality is, each of us have the *power to forgive* anything but that doesn't mean that a person is *willing to forgive* anything or that the act of forgiveness will be easy. And sometimes a wrong is so horrible that it can take the rest of one's life to forgive completely. But the possibility is there.

forgiveness is **a spiritual act**, which means that, ultimately, I rely on God's grace to accomplish it. In fact, my own faults and weaknesses will get in the way of my ability to forgive, especially in some situations. But whatever I'm lacking, God can supply. At times my need for God's assistance is acute, but when I choose to forgive, my effort does not rely on any other person.

Reconciliation is a **multiple-person process**. When one person reconciles with another person, both of them must first ask and/or offer forgiveness. But it has to go further than that. Both people have to choose to do whatever it takes to restore the relationship. **One person might be completely willing, but if the other person is not willing, reconciliation isn't possible.**

This means that I can forgive someone for damaging our friendship, but maybe I don't feel safe enough to resume the friendship. Reconciliation might happen later, but for now I will forgive and leave it at that. Maybe I've already forgiven the person who has hurt me and I'm ready and able to reconcile, but the other person no longer desires the relationship. Or, it's possible the other person can forgive me but not want to reconcile; or the other person forgives me but I don't want to reconcile.

FORGIVENESS IS AN INTERIOR DISCIPLINE; RECONCILIATION IS AN OUTWARD PROCESS

Forgiveness is a private and ongoing discipline of mind, heart, and soul. Actually, forgiveness is one aspect of an overall posture toward others and life itself.

If I am judgmental and vindictive in general, forgiveness will be an awkward and difficult change of direction for me. If I hope to forgive specific wrongs others commit against me, then I should be practicing everyday to look at others with openness and compassion, to be slow to place blame and to resist seeking revenge. And I can even practice forgiveness without anyone else knowing what is happening inside me.

I may be super hurt at something another person said, and I know that before I confront that person in any way, I need to choose forgiveness. I might silently work on forgiveness—in my prayer, meditation, **talks with a counselor**—for days or weeks without talking directly to the person whose words hurt me.

Reconciliation, on the other hand, **is not private because it must include at least one other person.** When I'm working on reconciliation, of course I do my own interior work, but I must also cooperate with the larger work that involves others' personal difficulties and needs.

Reconciliation is as complicated as the people involved, **and it can require more time and patience than forgiveness because of all the moving pieces.** Another big factor in reconciliation is the inclusion—or, intrusion—of other friends and family members. Additional people can provide strength, encouragement, and wisdom. They can also provide more opportunities for argument, miscommunication, and flawed strategies.